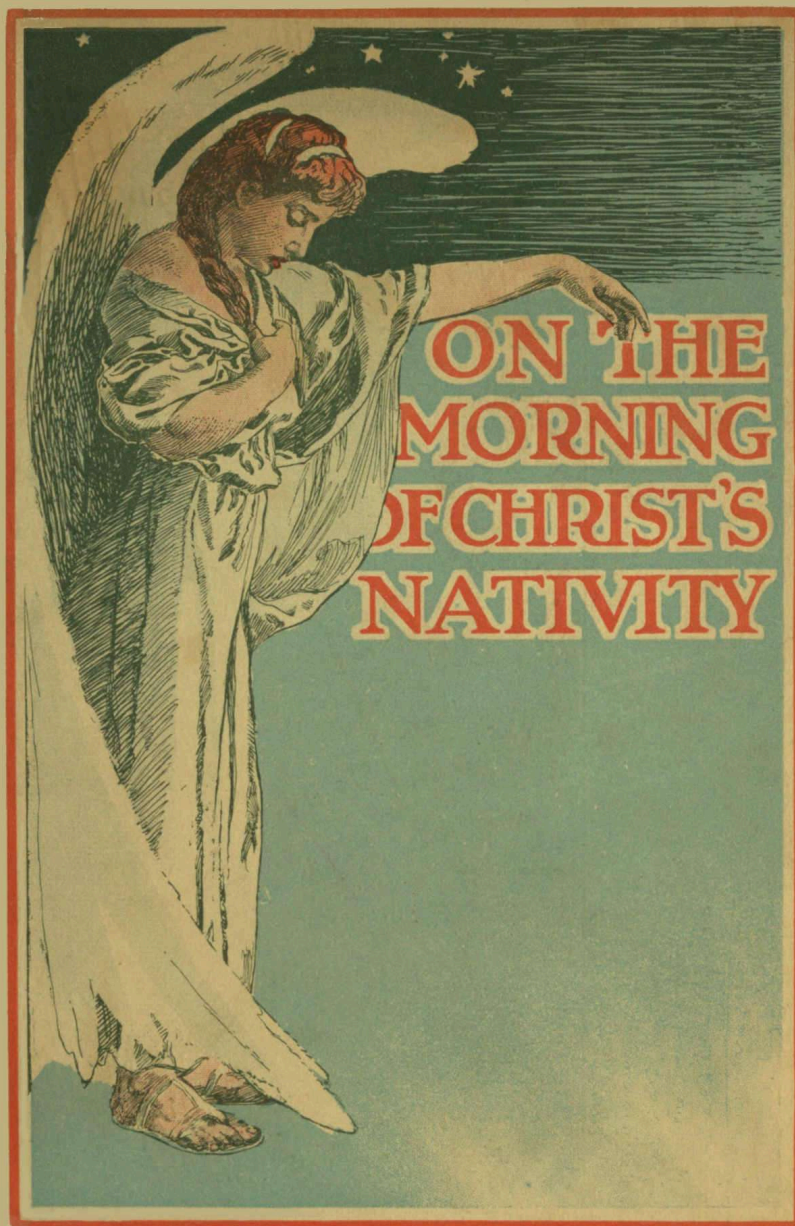






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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK ON THE
MORNING OF CHRIST'S NATIVITY ***

ON THE MORNING OF CHRIST'S NATIVITY

An Ode by
JOHN MILTON

Designed and Hand-lettered by
RALPH FLETCHER SEYMOUR



1910

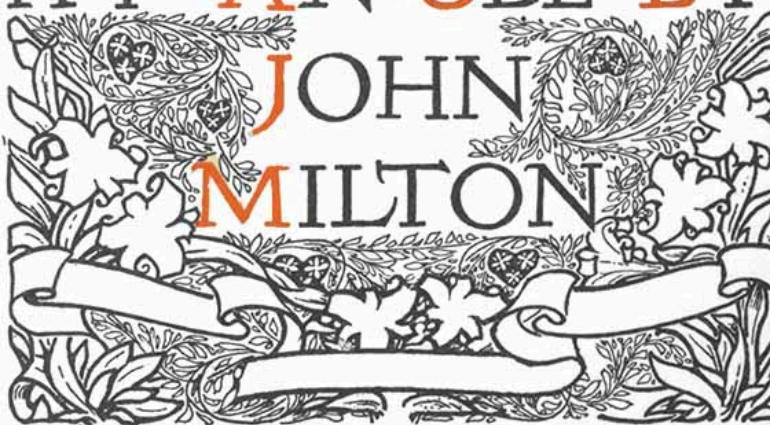
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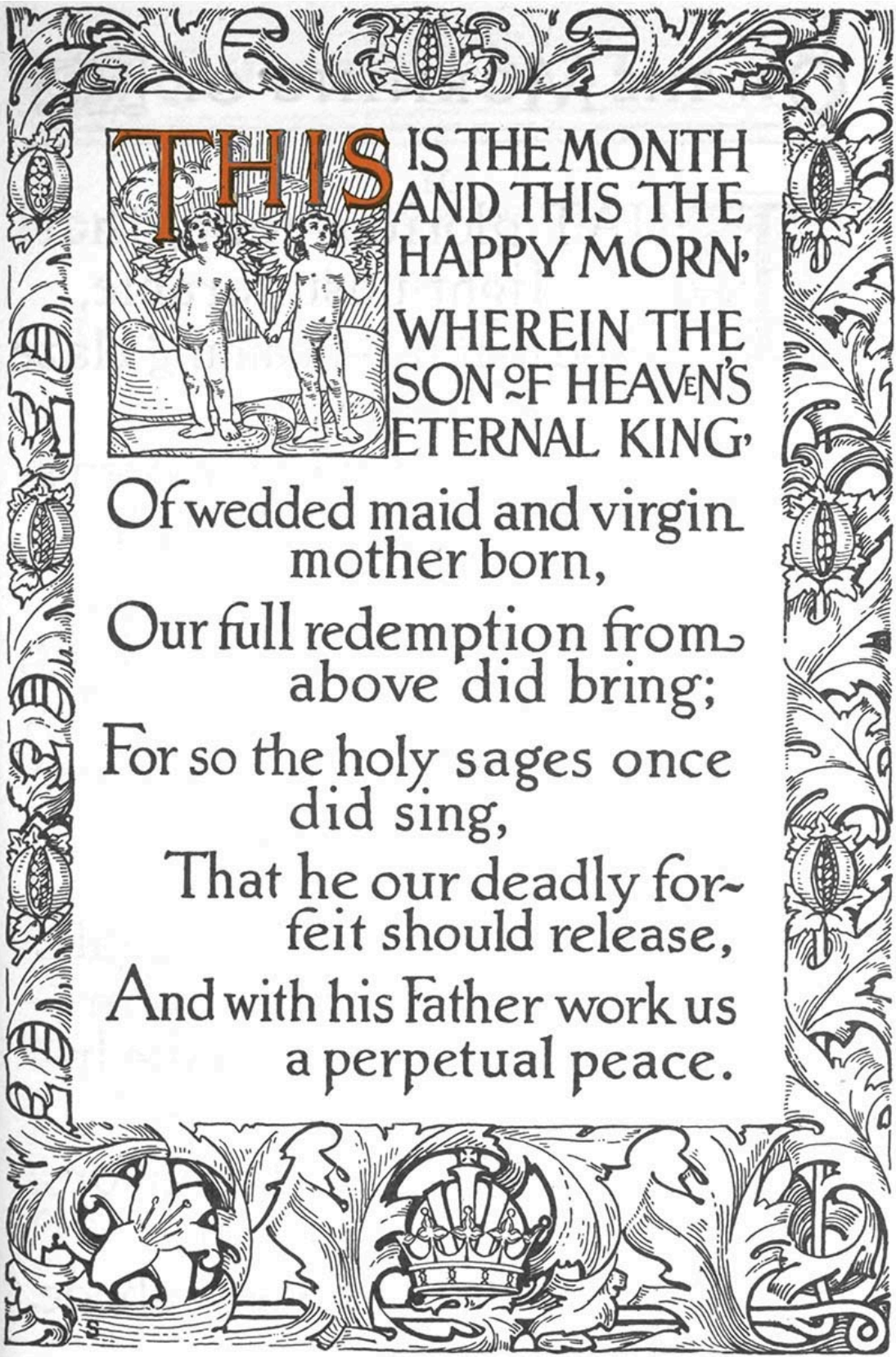
ON THE MORNING OF
CHRIST'S NATIVITY



ON THE MORNING
OF CHRIST'S NATIV-
ITY—AN ODE BY
JOHN
MILTON



ON THE MORNING
OF CHRIST'S NATIVITY—AN
ODE BY
JOHN MILTON



THIS IS THE MONTH
AND THIS THE
HAPPY MORN,
WHEREIN THE
SON OF HEAVEN'S
ETERNAL KING,

Of wedded maid and virgin
mother born,
Our full redemption from
above did bring;
For so the holy sages once
did sing,
That he our deadly for-
feit should release,
And with his Father work us
a perpetual peace.

This is the month and this the happy morn,

Wherein the son of heaven's eternal king,
Of wedded maid and virgin mother born,
Our full redemption from above did bring;
For so the holy sages once did sing,
That he our deadly forfeit should release,
And with his Father work us a perpetual peace.

II

HAT glorious form, that light unsufferable,
And that far-beaming blaze of majesty,
Wherewith he wont at Heaven's high council-
table
To sit the midst of Trinal Unity,
He laid aside; and, here with us to be,
Forsook the courts of everlasting day,
And chose with us a darksome house of mortal clay.

III

AY, heavenly Muse, shall not thy sacred vein
Afford a present to the Infant God?
Hast thou no verse, no hymn, or solemn strain,
To welcome him to this his new abode,
Now, while the heaven, by the sun's team untrod,
Hath took no print of the approaching light,
And all the spangled host keep watch in squadrons bright?

IV

EE how from far upon the eastern road
The star-led wizards haste with odours sweet;
Oh! run, prevent them with thy humble ode,
And lay it lowly at his blessed feet;
Have thou the honour first thy Lord to greet,
And join thy voice unto the angel choir,
From out his secret altar touched with hallowed fire.



THE HYMN



It was the winter wild,
While the Heaven-born child
All meanly wrapped in the rude manger
lies;
Nature in awe to him
Had doffed her gaudy trim,
With her great Master so to sympathize:
It was no season then for her
To wanton with the sun, her lusty paramour.

II



ONLY, with speeches fair
She wooes the gentle air

To hide her guilty front with innocent snow,
And on her naked shame,
Pollute with sinful blame,
The saintly veil of maiden white to throw;
Confounded that her Maker's eyes
Should look so near upon her foul deformities.

III

BUT he, her fears to cease,
Sent down the meek-eyed Peace;
She, crowned with olive green, came softly
sliding
Down through the turning sphere,
His ready harbinger,
With turtle wing the amorous clouds dividing;
And, waving wide her myrtle wand,
She strikes an universal peace through sea and land.

IV

NO war, or battle's sound,
Was heard the world around;
The idle spear and shield were high up hung;
The hookèd chariot stood,
Unstained with hostile blood;
The trumpet spake not to the armèd throng;
And kings sat still with awful eye,
As if they surely knew their sovereign Lord was by.

V

BUT peaceful was the night
Wherein the Prince of Light
His reign of peace upon the earth began:
The winds, with wonder whist,
Smoothly the waters kissed,
Whispering new joys to the mild ocean,
Who now hath quite forgot to rave,
Who now hath quite forgot to rave,

While birds of calm sit brooding on the charmèd wave.

VI

THE stars, with deep amaze,
Stand fixed in steadfast gaze,
 Bending one way their precious influence,
And will not take their flight
For all the morning light,
 Or Lucifer that often warned them thence;
But in their glimmering orbs did glow,
Until their Lord himself bespake, and bid them go.

VII

AND, though the shady gloom
Had given day her room,
 The sun himself withheld his wonted speed,
And hid his head for shame,
As his inferior flame
 The new enlightened world no more should need;
He saw a greater Sun appear
Than his bright throne or burning axle-tree could bear.



VIII

THE shepherds on the lawn,
Or ere the point of dawn,
Sat simply chatting in a rustic row;
Full little thought they then,
That the mighty Pan
Was kindly come to live with them below;
Perhaps their loves, or else their sheep,
Was all that did their silly thoughts so busy keep.

IX

WHEN such music sweet
Their hearts and ears did greet,
As never was by mortal finger strook,
Divinely-warbled voice
Answering the stringèd noise,
As all their souls in blissful rapture took;

The air, such pleasure loth to lose,
With thousand echoes still prolongs each heavenly close.

X

NATURE, that heard such sound,
Beneath the hollow round
Of Cynthia's seat, the airy region thrilling,
Now was almost won
To think her part was done,
And that her reign had here its last fulfilling;
She knew such harmony alone
Could hold all Heaven and Earth in happier union.

XI

AT last surrounds their sight
A globe of circular light,
That with long beams the shame-faced Night
arrayed;
The helmèd Cherubim,
And sworded Seraphim,
Are seen in glittering ranks with wings displayed,
Harping in loud and solemn choir,
With unexpressive notes, to Heaven's new-born Heir.

XII

SUCH music (as 'tis said)
Before was never made,
But when of old the Sons of Morning sung,
While the Creator great
His constellations set,
And the well-balanced world on hinges hung,
And cast the dark foundations deep,
And bid the weltering waves their oozy channel keep.

XIII

RING out, ye crystal Spheres!
Once bless our human ears
 (If ye have power to touch our senses so),
And let your silver chime
Move in melodious time;
 And let the base of Heaven's deep organ blow,
And with your ninefold harmony
Make up full consort to the angelic symphony.

XIV

FOR if such holy song
Enwrap our fancy long,
 Time will run back, and fetch the age of gold;
And speckled Vanity
Will sicken soon and die,
 And leprous Sin will melt from earthly mold;
And Hell itself will pass away,
And leave her dolorous mansions to the peering Day.

XV

YEA, Truth and Justice then
Will down return to men,
 Orbed in a rainbow; and, like glories wearing,
Mercy will sit between,
Throned in celestial sheen,
 With radiant feet the tissued clouds down steering;
And Heaven, as at some festival,
Will open wide the gates of her high palace hall.

XVI

BUT wisest Fate says No,
This must not yet be so,
 The Babe lies yet in smiling infancy,
That on the bitter cross
Must redeem our loss,
 So both himself and us to glorify;

Yet first, to those ychained in sleep,
The wakeful trump of doom must thunder through the deep,

XVII

WITH such a horrid clang
As on Mount Sinai rang,
While the red fire and smouldering clouds
outbrake;
The agèd Earth aghast,
With terror of that blast,
Shall from the surface to the center shake;
When at the world's last session,
The dreadful Judge in middle air shall spread his throne.

XVIII

AND then at last our bliss
Full and perfect is,
But now begins; for from this happy day
The old Dragon under ground,
In straiter limits bound,
Not half so far casts his usurpèd sway,
And, wroth to see his kingdom fail,
Swindges the scaly horror of his folded tail.



XIX

THE oracles are dumb,
No voice or hideous hum
Runs through the arched roof in words
deceiving.
Apollo from his shrine
Can no more divine,
With hollow shriek the steep of Delphos leaving.
No nightly trance, or breathèd spell,
Inspires the pale-eyed priest from the prophetic cell.

XX

THE lonely mountains o'er
And the resounding shore,
A voice of weeping heard and loud lament;
From haunted spring, and dale

Edged with poplar pale,
The parting Genius is with sighing sent;
With flower-inwoven tresses torn
The Nymphs in twilight shade of tangled thickets mourn.

XXI

IN consecrated earth,
And on the holy hearth,
The Lars and Lemures moan with midnight
plaint;
In urns, and altars round,
A drear and dying sound
Affrights the Flamens at their service quaint;
And the chill marble seems to sweat,
While each peculiar Power forgoes his wonted seat.

XXII

PEOR and Baälim
Forsake their temples dim,
With that twice-battered god of Palestine;
And moonèd Ashtaroth,
Heaven's queen and mother both,
Now sits not girt with taper's holy shine;
The Lybic Hammon shrinks his horn;
In vain the Tyrian maids their wounded Thammuz mourn.

XXIII

AND sullen Moloch, fled,
Hath left in shadows dread
His burning idol all of blackest hue;
In vain, with cymbals' ring,
They call the grisly king,
In dismal dance about the furnace blue;
The brutish gods of Nile as fast,
Isis and Orus, and the dog Anubis, haste.

XXIV

NOR is Osiris seen
In Memphian grove or green,
Trampling the unshowered grass with lowings loud;
Nor can he be at rest
Within his sacred chest,
Nought but profoundest Hell can be his shroud!
In vain with timbreled anthems dark
The sable-stolèd sorcerers bear his worshipped ark.

XXV

HE feels from Judah's land
The dreaded infant's hand,
The rays of Bethlehem blind his dusky eyn;
Nor all the gods beside
Longer dare abide,
Nor Typhon huge ending in snaky twine,
Our Babe, to show his Godhead true,
Can in His swaddling bands control the damnèd crew.



XXVI

SO when the sun in bed,
 Curtained with cloudy red,
 Pillows his chin upon an orient wave,
 The flocking shadows pale
 Troop to the infernal jail,
 Each fettered ghost slips to his several grave;
 And the yellow-skirted fays
 Fly after the night-steeds, leaving their moon-loved maze.

XXVII

BUT see, the Virgin blest
 Hath laid her Babe to rest;
 Time is our tedious song should here have ending;
 Heaven's youngest-teemèd star
 Hath fixed her polished car,

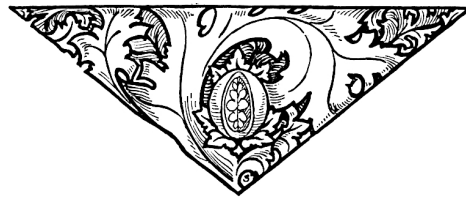
Her sleeping Lord with handmaid lamp attending;
And all about the courtly stable
Bright-harnessed angels sit in order serviceable.





HERE ENDS THIS POEM: TRULY BY ITS SONG OUR NOBLE
POET HAS ENLARGED OUR JOY. AS HE HAS WRITTEN, __

“Of music, and ethereal mirth
Wherewith the stage of Air and Earth did ring,
And joyous news of heavenly Infant’s birth
My muse with Angels did divide to sing.”



VALE QUI LEGIS

Transcriber’s Notes

Except for the changes noted below, which were verified by external sources,
original spelling and punctuation have been retained.

Stanza XXVII of the Hymn: “handmade” was replaced with
“handmaid”.

Final quotation: “Infants’ birth” was replaced with “Infant’s birth”.

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